

Ἀντιφῶν ὁ Ἀθηναῖος

Antiphon of Athens in the Law Courts and the Assembly

eul_aid: bqs

Period: [Κλασική](#) [Classical](#)

Dialect: [Ἀττική](#) [Attic](#)

Domain: [Ῥητορική](#) [Oratory](#)

Format: [Λόγος](#) [Oration](#)

Affiliation: [Sophist](#)

Antiphon was an Athenian intellectual active in the late 5th century BCE. Traditionally identified as a sophist, he was a teacher of rhetoric and a professional speechwriter who composed legal arguments for others to deliver in court. Modern scholarship regards him as a complex figure, as ancient sources may refer to more than one person with this name. The prevailing view is that the speechwriter, the sophist philosopher, and the oligarchic politician were the same individual.

His surviving works fall into two categories. Three complete courtroom speeches survive, representing the earliest examples of Athenian forensic oratory. He also wrote philosophical works and rhetorical exercises known as the Tetralogies, which explore legal principles and hypothetical arguments. Fragments of his treatises, such as **On Truth**, contain sophisticated discussions on nature, justice, and human convention.

Politically, Antiphon was a leading member of the oligarchic government known as the Four Hundred, which briefly overthrew the Athenian democracy in 411 BCE. After democracy was restored, he was tried for treason, convicted, and executed. The historian Thucydides praised his defense speech, though it has not survived.

Antiphon is considered a foundational figure in the history of rhetoric, often called the first Athenian speechwriter whose works survive. His writings provide crucial insight into Athenian law, society, and the intellectual debates of the Sophistic movement during the Peloponnesian War.

Works (9)

- [Ἀποσπάσματα περὶ Ὀλιγαρχίας καὶ Δημοκρατίας](#) · [Fragments on Oligarchy and Democracy](#) · 9 passages
- [Ἀποσπάσματα](#) · [On Sedition and Political Defense](#) · 132 passages
- [Φαρμακείας κατὰ τῆς μητρὸς](#) · [On Sorcery-The Stepmother](#) · 27 passages
- [Περὶ τοῦ χορευτοῦ](#) · [On the Dancer](#) · 39 passages
- [Περὶ τοῦ Ἡρώδου φόνου](#) · [On the Murder of Herodes](#) · 85 passages
- [Ἀποσπάσματα](#) · [On the Samothracian Tribute](#) · 33 passages
- [Τετραλογία Α΄](#) · [Tetralogy A](#) · 38 passages
- [Τετραλογία Β΄](#) · [Tetralogy B](#) · 31 passages
- [Τετραλογία Γ΄](#) · [Tetralogy C](#) · 29 passages

Other Sophist Authors

- Ἀχιλλεύς ὁ Τατίος ὁ Ἀλεξανδρεὺς · Achilles Tati of Alexandria · 1 work
- Κλαύδιος Αἰλιανός · Aelian of Praeneste · 4 works
- Πόπλιος Αἴλιος Ἀριστείδης Θεόδωρος · Aelius Aristides of Smyrna · 3 works
- Αἴλιος Διονύσιος ὁ Ἀλικαρνασσεύς · Aelius Dionysius of Halicarnassus · 1 work
- Αἴλιος Θεών ὁ σοφιστής · Aelius Theon the Sophist · 1 work
- Ἀλκιδάμας ὁ Ἐλαεύς · Alcidamas of Elaea · 1 work
- Ἀλκίφρων ὁ Σοφιστής · Alciphron the Sophist · 1 work
- Ἀλέξανδρος ὁ τοῦ Νουμήνιου · Alexander Son of Numenius · 2 works
- Ἀλέξανδρος ὁ Ἐφέσιος · Alexander the Ephesian Poet · 1 work
- Ἀμφικράτης Ἀθηναῖος · Amphicrates Atheniensis · 1 work
- Ἀνώνυμος ὑπόμνημα εἰς Ἀφθόνιον · Anonymous Commentary on Aphthonius · 2 works
- Ἀντιφῶν ὁ Ῥαμνοῦσιος · Antiphon of Rhamnus · 1 work